

The Algarve Secret Guide

Product Blueprint

A comprehensive planning document for creating your premium digital guide

Overview

Product	The Algarve Secret Guide
Format	PDF (primary) + Notion option
Price Point	€19–25
Update Cycle	Quarterly
Target Launch	After 1,500+ subscribers with 40%+ open rate

Core Promise

"The places tourists miss and locals actually go — curated by someone who lives here."

This isn't a travel guide. It's a local's honest cheat sheet for people who want to skip the tourist traps and experience the Algarve the way residents do.

What Makes This Guide Worth Buying

What People Get	Why It Matters
Curation, not comprehensiveness	50 places that earned their spot, not 500 listings
Honest opinions	"Skip this", "overrated", "only worth it before 10am"
Insider timing	When to go, when to avoid, seasonal notes
Practical details	Parking, exact locations, what to order, which entrance
Trust transfer	Same voice as the newsletter they already love

Complete Structure

Cover + Opening

- **Title page** with clean design
- **About the author** — brief, personal, establishes credibility as a local
- **How to use this guide** — navigation tips, icons explained
- **Last updated** date (builds trust, shows it's maintained)

Section 1: Beaches (The Core Draw)

15–20 beaches organised by what people actually want:

Categories:

- **Hidden Coves** — small, hard to find, worth the effort
- **Family-Friendly** — calm water, easy access, nearby amenities
- **Wild & Dramatic** — cliffs, waves, photographers
- **Best for Sunrise/Sunset** — specific spots, exact timing

For Each Beach Include:

- Name + location (with GPS coordinates)
- **Vibe in one line** (e.g., "Tiny cove, feels private, rope access")
- **Best time to visit** — hour of day, season, crowd patterns
- **Parking situation** — honest assessment, alternatives
- **Facilities** — or lack thereof
- **Personal take** — your honest opinion
- **Skip if...** — who it's NOT for

Example Entry:

Praia do Carvalho

■ Between Carvoeiro and Benagil • GPS: 37.0893, -8.4397

Vibe: Small beach accessed through a hand-carved tunnel in the cliff. Feels like discovering something.

Best time: Arrive before 9:30am in summer. After 11am, the small beach fills completely. Off-season is magic — often empty.

Parking: Small dirt lot at the top. Gets full fast. No nearby alternatives.

Facilities: None. Bring everything.

My take: One of my favourites for the sense of discovery. The tunnel alone is worth the visit. But manage expectations — it's tiny.

Skip if: You need shade, facilities, or space. Families with very young kids will find the access tricky.

Section 2: Restaurants Locals Actually Go To

25–30 restaurants organised by type:

Categories:

- **Traditional Portuguese** — the real thing, not tourist versions
- **Seafood Done Right** — where to get proper fresh fish
- **Hidden Gems** — places tourists never find
- **Worth the Splurge** — special occasions, fine dining
- **Quick & Honest** — tasca, petiscos, no frills
- **Best Views** — when the setting matters

For Each Restaurant Include:

- Name + location
- **What they're known for** — 1-2 signature dishes
- **Price range** — €/€/€/€€€
- **Reservation needed?** — honest assessment
- **Best for** — couples, families, groups, solo
- **What to order** — specific recommendations
- **What to skip** — if applicable
- **Insider tip** — booking time, seating request, etc.

Section 3: Towns by Vibe

8–10 town profiles helping readers choose where to stay or visit:

Town	Vibe
Lagos	Young, lively, beaches
Tavira	Elegant, calm, authentic
Faro	Underrated, real city, good base
Silves	History, inland escape
Carvoeiro	Family-friendly, accessible
Sagres	Surfers, edge of the world
Olhão	Working town, Ria Formosa, markets

Loulé	Market, interior, local life
-------	------------------------------

For Each Town:

- **One-line vibe** — what it feels like
- **Best for** — type of traveller
- **Stay if... / Skip if...** — honest criteria
- **Don't miss** — 2-3 specific spots
- **Where to eat** — 1-2 quick picks
- **Day trip potential** — what's nearby

Section 4: Tourist Traps to Skip

This section alone justifies the purchase.

- Specific places/experiences that are overpriced, overcrowded, or underwhelming
- Why they're traps
- What to do instead (the local alternative)

Examples:

- The main Benagil boat tours (do this instead...)
- That "famous" restaurant in [town] (locals go here instead...)
- The beach everyone posts on Instagram (similar vibes, half the crowd...)

Tone: Not mean, but honest. "It's fine, but here's what you're missing."

Section 5: Timing Hacks

The secret knowledge that takes years to learn:

- **Monthly calendar** — what each month is actually like
- **Best time to visit each type of attraction**
- **When to avoid** — specific dates, local holidays, cruise ship days
- **Seasonal secrets** — what's good in off-season, what's only good in summer
- **Golden hours** — specific times when popular spots are empty

Example — The Benagil Timing Hack:

Everyone goes mid-morning. The cave is packed 10am–4pm.

Instead: Book a kayak tour that leaves at 7:30am (yes, they exist). You'll have the cave nearly to yourself, the light is better for photos, and the sea is calmer.

Or: Go in November–March. The tours still run on good weather days, and you might be the only boat there.

Section 6: Practical Essentials

Quick-reference section:

- **Getting around** — car vs no car, parking tips, toll roads explained
- **Money matters** — tipping, cash vs card, what's expensive

- **Useful Portuguese phrases** — the 15 that actually matter
- **Apps to download** — the ones locals use
- **Emergency info** — hospitals, pharmacies, police

Section 7: Day Trips & Drives

5–7 curated itineraries:

- The Western Coast (Sagres, Cape St. Vincent)
- Ria Formosa & Eastern Algarve
- Mountain Escape (Monchique, Silves, Caldas)
- The Secret Beaches Drive
- Over the Border (Seville day trip)

For each itinerary: Route with stops, timing recommendations, where to eat along the way, what to skip.

Design & Format Recommendations

Visual Style:

- Clean, modern, scannable
- Consistent iconography for categories
- High-quality photos (your own if possible — authenticity)
- Maps for each section (simple, not overwhelming)
- QR codes linking to Google Maps locations

Practical Details:

- **PDF:** Optimised for both screen reading and printing
- **Notion option:** Interactive, updatable, links work
- **Length:** 40–60 pages feels substantial but not overwhelming
- **Mobile-friendly:** Most people will read on phone

Pricing Strategy

Price	Rationale
€19	Entry point, low friction, good for testing
€25	Premium positioning once proven

€15	Launch discount / newsletter subscriber price
-----	---

Recommendation: Launch at €19 with a €15 subscriber-only price for the first 2 weeks. This rewards your loyal readers and creates urgency.

Launch Sequence

Timeline	Action
Week -2	Tease in newsletter ("I'm working on something...")
Week -1	Reveal what it is + early access signup for subscribers
Launch Day	Email to full list, subscriber discount (€15 for 48 hours), social posts
Week +1	Follow-up email to non-buyers, price goes to full €19, share early feedback

Future Expansion Options

Once the main guide succeeds, you can spin off:

Guide	Price	Audience
Beach Guide (expanded)	€9–12	Beach lovers
Restaurant Map	€12–15	Foodies
Off-Season Guide	€9–12	Winter visitors
Expat Starter Guide	€29–39	New residents
Family Algarve Guide	€12–15	Parents
Digital Nomad Guide	€15–25	Remote workers
Golf Guide	€15–25	Golfers

Success Metrics

- **Conversion rate:** 2–5% of list is healthy
- **Revenue target:** 100 sales × €19 = €1,900 (achievable at 3k subscribers)
- **Refund rate:** Under 5% means product-market fit
- **Qualitative:** Unprompted testimonials, social shares

Key Principle

"Every page should make the reader think: I couldn't have found this on Google."

That's the bar. If it's easily searchable, it doesn't belong in a paid guide. Your value is curation, opinion, and local knowledge that takes years to accumulate.

This blueprint is designed to help you create a guide that sells because it's genuinely useful — not because of marketing tricks. The trust you build with your newsletter is your distribution. The guide is just the proof that your recommendations are worth paying for.